

weathered rock formations. As a result, the building seems to be in a state of permanently shimmering movement—almost as if it is alive. The effect is greatly heightened where the balconies disappear entirely, revealing areas of blue glass that look like vertical pools of water. It is a multiuse building, with shops; offices; a hotel; and, from the 19th story upward, 739 apartments. The roof is given over to a vast, intricately landscaped garden.

Central and South America

Tiwanaku

Location Province of Ingavi, Bolivia

Once the heart of Tiwanaku Culture, Tiwanaku was the capital of a pre-Hispanic empire that ruled over part of the southern Andes. The city flourished between 400 and 900 CE and had a strong civic character. A series of buildings underline the importance of the political and religious power within the city; these include the Palace of Putuni and Kantatallita, the semi-subterranean Temple, Kalasasaya's Temple, Pumapumku's Pyramid, and Akapana's Pyramid—arguably Tiwanaku's most imposing structure. Much of the architecture was made out of carefully carved ashlar (finely cut stone) masonry, while the urban plan boasts a complex system of underground drainage that controlled the flow of rainwater.

► ENGRAVED DEITY STATUE AT THE ENTRANCE TO TIWANAKU'S TEMPLE COURT

Temple of the Sun

Location Trujillo, Peru

Built by the ancient civilization of Moche, also known as Mochica, this giant temple is one half of a pair of large-scale religious structures nestled in the Moche river valley, just outside the city of Trujillo in northern Peru (the other being the Temple of the Moon). The stepped, pyramidal temple, built from adobe brick, spans an impressive 1,115 ft (340 m) and is 135 ft (41 m) high. Sitting within a site that was densely occupied between the 1st and 8th centuries CE, this monument was, spatially and socially, the heart of this Moche urban center.

Pyramid of the Magician

Location Uxmal, Mexico

The Pyramid of the Magician is unusual, in that it is set on an oval footprint and has rounded edges. Located in Mexico's ancient Maya city of Uxmal in Yucatán, the dramatic, 91-ft- (27.6-m-) high structure is the tallest building in the entire archaeological site. It was completed in about 900 CE. Uxmal is representative of the region's Puuc architectural style, and the pyramid is no exception, featuring stone decorations and a concrete core. Two steep and massive staircases lead to the top of the pyramid on the east and west sides. The structure contains a series of five nested temples resulting from successive building phases.

Governor's Palace

Location Uxmal, Mexico

The Governor's Palace at Uxmal is one of Mexico's most instantly recognizable pre-Columbian structures. Elevated on an 26-ft- (8-m-) high platform that can be reached by a dramatic stairway with three landings, this administrative center was built in the 10th century. Despite the palace's imposing setting and impressive size—it is about 330 ft (100 m) in length—its most eye-catching feature is arguably the facade's intricate relief decorations, crowned by a mosaic frieze. The decorations include an abundance of glyphs representing Venus, and the palace itself is aligned toward the point where the planet rises in the southernmost part of its cycle.

Aqua Tower

Location Chicago, Illinois

Opened in 2010, the Aqua Tower, designed by Studio Gang Architects, is an 82-story, 876-ft- (267-m-) tall skyscraper close to the shores of Lake Michigan. Its most obvious feature is its series of alternately projecting and receding balconies. These give the building an organic quality, with echoes of naturally

